

R IRANI



Sentenced for Life

DELHI Nine years after fashion designer Kunjum Budhiraja was stabbed to death at a farmhouse at Mehrauli in south Delhi, the city Patiala House court convicted former high-flying Congressman and alleged aide of underworld don Dawood Ibrahim, Romesh Sharma, for her murder. The court also imposed a fine of Rs 50,000 on Sharma who—along with his nephew Surinder Mishra, close associate Tejinder

Virdi alias Dolly, and three others—was held guilty of hatching a criminal conspiracy to eliminate Budhiraja. The probe found that Mishra, Dolly and another accused, Jaspreet Virdi alias Sonu, wanted to get rid of Budhiraja as they felt that while they were taking care of Sharma, he was planning to give away his property to Budhiraja.

Sharma's girlfriend Budhiraja was found murdered at his farmhouse on

CONVICTED: Sharma

March 20, 1999. She had gone to offer navratra prayers at a temple built by Sharma at his farmhouse. Following her death, Sharma—who was lodged in Tihar Jail—came out on parole to attend her cremation. In a dramatic show of affection, he “married” Budhiraja’s corpse on the pyre.

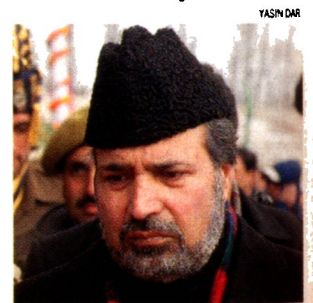
A chargesheet was filed on June 16, 1999, and 64 witnesses were produced in court, most of whom later turned hostile. But the court announced its verdict based on the theory of the prosecution which questioned the motive behind Budhiraja’s murder. The prosecution claimed that the exchange of letters between Sharma and Budhiraja was strong circumstantial evidence, which proved him guilty.

Sharma will appeal against the conviction in the Delhi High Court. He has been in judicial custody since 1999 and is facing trial in 16 criminal cases.

by Manoj Verma

Landing a Dispute

SRINAGAR To sell or not to sell land to non-state subjects has stirred a hornet’s nest in Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) ahead of Assembly polls due in October this year. Deputy Chief Minister and senior PDP leader Muzaffar Hussain Baig recently said in Delhi, “I want to dispel the notion that Indians cannot buy land in Jammu and Kashmir. There is a provision in our Constitution by which



FOOT IN HIS MOUTH: Baig they can invest in industry, tourism and health sectors.” The statement drew flak from the Opposition National Conference which accused coalition partner PDP of undermining the Constitution of J&K. Even the Congress, the PDP’s coalition ally, distanced itself from Baig’s spur ‘statement’ saying, “If he has said it, he should not have said it at all.”

Baig immediately retracted his statement and said that the state’s Constitution did not permit outsiders to buy land in J&K. Last year, the state Government had to roll back plans to lease out prime land to outsiders at Gulmarg amid widespread condemnation and allegations that it was a part of Delhi’s “hidden agenda” to erode the special status of the state.

by Aljaz Hussain

OBJECT OF DESIRE

Time Travel

**HARRY WINSTON Z4
ZALIUM WATCH
Rs 12.54 lakh**

It winds its way through three time zones with two separate hour-and-minute dials displaying daytime and night-time for each time zone. The repeater style trigger on the left side of the case allows clicking from one time zone to the next. The easy-to-read date is framed vertically in the interplay of discs for the minute display and hour. The watch is crafted from zalium developed for use in jet engines with hypo-allergenic properties and extreme resistance to corrosion. The ideal traveller’s watch.

